# From the Balkans to Baghdad: The Ottoman World, 1300-1850



Over its 600-year history, the lands claimed by the Ottoman dynasty in Europe, Asia, and Africa became increasingly entangled via economic, social, and cultural channels. Networks of trade, knowledge, and power stretched from Belgrade to Baghdad and from the Crimea to Cairo (in the latter case, far more directly than is commonly known today). Traces of this world can still be found in the 21st century, though often only vaguely discernible amidst the bits of language, architecture, and memory which have survived the onslaught of nationalist erasure in the 20th century.

This course takes students through the history of the empire by using different perspectives to ask what it meant to live in the Ottoman world during the early modern period. We will explore the Ottoman experience on a thematic basis and cover topics that including coexistence, trade networks, institutional and technological innovation, class divisions and slavery, environmental crises, rebellion, and reform in the modern age.

**Analytical questions**

What did it mean to be an Ottoman?
What was the impact of Ottoman expansion on the lands of the empire?
What was the significance of the empire in world history?
How is the Ottoman past important to understanding post-Ottoman lands today?

**Grade basis**

25% Participation
30% Mid-term paper  Write a primary source analysis using either *Memoirs of a Janissary* or *An Ottoman traveler*.
15% Map quizzes  These are simple exercises to improve your knowledge of the region's geography. We will learn the material together and you will be expected to memorize it for the in-class quiz.
30% Final paper  Explore the notion of the Ottoman "world" using the readings we cover in the course. Was it a coherent concept? You should anchor your argument in at least two specific case studies – that is, regions, texts, historical actors, or objects/commodities.

**Required texts**

1. Evliya Çelebi, *An Ottoman traveler: selections from the book of travels of Evliya Çelebi* (2010)
2. Cemal Kafadar, *Between two worlds* (1995)
3. Konstanty Michalowicz, *Memoirs of a Janissary* (2010)
4. Baki Tezcan, *The second Ottoman Empire: Political and social transformation in the early modern world* (2011)
5. Sam White, "In the wake of the Celalis: Climate and crisis in the seventeenth century," chapter from *the Climate of Rebellion in the Ottoman Empire* (2011)
6. Ali Yaycıoğlu, *Partners of the Empire: the crisis of the Ottoman order in the age of revolutions* (2016)

## Course schedule

**1 Deep history**

**Session 1** Introduction to the Ottomans and the Eurasian context
→ Molly Greene, "The Ottoman Experience," *Daedalus: Journal of the American Acadey of Arts and Sciences* 134 (Spring 2005): 88-99
→ Barry Cunliffe, *By steppe, desert, and ocean: the birth of Eurasia* (2015), 1-34; 451-472.
Discussion What are the major geographic structures which shape Eurasia, and what is at stake in using this term (why not Afro-Eurasia)? What is the relationship between geography and history?

**Session 2** Seas, Mountains, and River Valleys
→ "The Mediterranean climate," A companion to Mediterranean history, Wiley Blackwell (2014)
→ Kramers, J.H., "al-Nīl", in: Encyclopaedia of Islam, Second Edition (2012), sections
→ Charles King, *The Black Sea: a history* (2004), 3-24.
Discussion What geographic advantages and disadvantages did the Ottomans face? How did the Mediterranean and Black Seas historically foster economic and political networks? Is it fair to consider these geographic zones as regions – why or why not?

**2 Ecologies**

**Session 1** Human geography
→ Sam White, T*he Climate of Rebellion in the Ottoman Empire* (2011), 20-51 ("Regions, resources, and settlement")
→ Gábor Ágoston, "Where Environmental and Frontier Studies Meet: Rivers, Forests, Marshes and Forts along the Ottoman-Hapsburg Frontier in Hungary," The Frontiers of the Ottoman World (Oxford: Oxford University Press), pp. 57-80
→ Carl M. Kortepeter, "Ottoman imperial policy and the economy of the Black Sea region in the 16th century," *Journal of the American Oriental Society* (1966), read only 97-113, *skim*

Discussion How did resource distribution function and why was it important in the early modern context? What were the major population centers of the empire and its most vital resources?

**Session 2** Animals
→ Barry Cunliffe, *By steppe, desert, and ocean: the birth of Eurasia* (2015), 415-451 ("1150-1300: the steppe triumphant")
→ Alain Mikhail, *The Animal in Ottoman Egypt* (2014), sections.
Discussion What was the significance of human-animal relations in the early modern era? What was the role of the horse in particular? What impact did the fauna of the Ottoman world have on its history?

*Map quiz – Mediterranean geography

**3 Peoples**

**Session 1** Ottoman Turks?
→ Andre Wink, "Post-nomadic empires: from the Mongols to the Mughals," *Tributary Empires in Global History* (2011)
→ Cornell Fleischer, *Bureaucrat and Intellectual in the Ottoman Empire: the historian Mustafa Ali* (1986), 253-292 ("Muslim and Ottoman" and "The Turkic and Mongol heritage")
Discussion What was the meaning of Ottoman, and what was its relationship to being a Turk? How did actors create these identities and how did they circulate over time? Did they have any contradictions within them?

**Session 2** Coexistence and confessionalism
→ Baki Tezcan, "Ethnicity, Race, religion and Social Class: Ottoman Markers of Difference," in Christine Woodhead ed, *The Ottoman World* (Oxon: Routledge, 2012), pp. 159-169
→ Martin Jacobs, "Sephardic Migration and Cultural Transfer: The Ottoman and Spanish Expansion through a Cinquecento Jewish Lens," *Journal of Early Modern History* 21 (2017), pp. 516-42
→ Molly Green, *A shared world: Christians and Muslims in the early modern Mediterranean* (2000), selections
Discussion What role did these groups have in the empire? What is the problem with thinking of them as "minorities"?

**4 Formation**

**Session 1** Debates on the early state
→ Heath W. Lowry, *The nature of the early Ottoman state* (2003)
→ Linda Darling, "Contested territory: Ottoman holy war in comparative perspective" *Studia Islamica* (2000): pp.133-163
→ Cemal Kafadar, *Between two worlds* (1995), ch. 3 "The Ottomans: the construction of the Ottoman state"
Discussion How can we describe the actors who constructed the early Ottoman state, and what were the reasons for their success?

**Session 2** Conquest
→ Halil Inalcik, “Ottoman methods of Conquest” *Studia Islamica* 2 (1954)
→ Nikolay Antov, *The Ottoman "Wild West": The Balkan Frontier in the Fifteenth and Sixteenth Centuries* (2017), p. 1-14, 41-93
→ Michael Winter, “Ottoman Egypt, 1525-1609,” *The Cambridge History of Egypt,* vol. 2: *Modern Egypt from 1517 to the end of the twentieth century*, edited by M.W. Daly (2008), pp.1-33
Discussion What were the most important early Ottoman innovations? How were early “core” provinces integrated into the empire?

*Map quiz – Black Sea geography

**5 Institutions**

**Session 1** The Janissary corps
→ Konstanty Michalowicz, *Memoirs of a Janissary* (2010), excerpts
→ Kafadar, “On the purity and corruption of the Janissaries,” *Turkish Studies Bulletin*, vol. 15, no. 2 (September 1991): 273-280
Discussion What was a Janissary, and what made the institution so effective? How did it change over time?

**Session 2** The legal system
→ Joshua White, *Piracy and Law in the Ottoman Mediterranean* (2018), selections
→ Karen Barkey, *Empire of Difference: the Ottomans in comparative perspective*, (2008), Ch.3, “Becoming an empire: imperial institutions and control”
Discussion Who were Ottoman judges and from where did they derive their authority?

*Map quiz - Regions

**6 Space and power**

**Session 1** Istanbul
→ Inalcik, “Istanbul, an Islamic city” (1954)
→ Evliya Çelebi, *An Ottoman traveler: selections from the book of travels of Evliya Çelebi* (2010), excerpts on Istanbul
→ Pinar Emiralioglu, *Geographical knowledge and imperial culture in the early modern Ottoman Empire* (2014)
Discussion What made Istanbul a metropole? What relationship did the city have to networks of power in the empire? How

**Session 2** The imperial harem
→ Leslie Peirce, “Writing Histories of Sexuality in the Middle East,” *The American Historical Review,* vol. 114, no. 5 (2009), pp. 1325-1339

→ Jane Hathaway, *The Chief Eunuch of the Ottoman Harem: From Africa Slave to Power-Broker* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2018), selections

Discussion How did the spatial organization of Ottoman power reflect gender norms? What were the political and social roles of women and eunuchs?

*Map quiz – Cities

**7 Networks**

**Session 1** Trade and communities

→ Sebouh Aslanian, *From the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean: the global trade networks of Armenian merchants from New Julfa* (2011)

→ Arakel of Tabriz, *History*, trans. Bournoutian (2005), excerpts

Discussion How did Armenian merchant networks function within and outside of Ottoman lands, and what advantages did they have? How does Arakel's view of the Armenian world fit into that of the Ottoman world?

**Session 2** Sufi networks

→ Ahmet Karamustafa, *God's Unruly Friends*, "Dervish groups in the Ottoman Empire, 1450-1550" (1994)

→ Dina LeGall, "Missionaries, pilgrims, and refugees: the early transmission of the Naqshbandiyya to the Ottoman lands," in *Modes de transmission de la culture religieuse en Islam*, ed. Elboudrari (1993), pp.225-240

Discussion What is Sufism? Who were some of the most important actors in Sufi movements? What was the relationship between these movements and the Ottoman state, or state-sanctioned religious institutions?

**8 Crises**

**Session 1** The Celali movements

→ Oktay Özel, *The collapse of rural order in Ottoman Anatolia* (2016), chapters 4 and 5

→ Sam White, "In the wake of the Celalis: Climate and crisis in the seventeenth century," chapter from *the Climate of Rebellion in the Ottoman Empire* (2011), 187-226

Discussion: What were the major factors in the Celali crisis? How were these a product of, or related to, the preceding imperial expansion? What is the relevant global context?

**Session 2** Transformation of the sinews of power

→ Baki Tezcan, *The second Ottoman Empire: Political and social transformation in the early modern world* (2011)

→ Halil Inalcik, "Military and fiscal transformation in the Ottoman Empire, 1600-1700," *AO* 6 (1980): 283-337

Discussion How did the Ottoman imperial order change during the 17th century?

**9 Stories and storytellers**

**Session 1** The early frontier epics

→ Yorgos Dedes, *The Battalname: Introduction, English Translation, Turkish Transcription, Commentary, and Facsimile* (1996), excerpts

Discussion What are the major identities of the epic? Why did the *Battalname* remain relevant if it supposedly recounted the story of the pre-Ottoman past?

**Session 2** Dede Korkut and Koroğlu

→ Geoffrey Lewis, "Kan Turali son of Kanli Koja," *The Book of Dede Korkut,* (1974)

→ Ali Aydin Karamustafa, *select article on Köroğlu epic background*

→ Watch clip of *Köroğlu* (1968)

Discussion Compare and contrast *Dede Korkut* to the *Battalname*. Think about *Köroğlu* in the context of the Celali crises and the transformation of the empire. Why might this story have appealed to a variety of peoples?

**10 The world of the new order**

**Session 1** New order politics

→ Ali Yaycıoğlu, *Partners of the Empire: the crisis of the Ottoman order in the age of revolutions* (2016), 1-116, *skim* the rest

→ Christine Philliou, *Biography of an Empire: governing Ottomans in an age of revolution* (2011), selections

Discussion What was the impulse for the "New Order," and how did the relations between the imperial center and provincial notables change during this period? What was the impact of the broader global context on Ottoman context? Use the example of the Ottoman Phanariot network to describe the competing intellectual and political networks of the empire in the 19th century.

**Session 2** Ottomans in the context of global modernities

→ Ahmad Dallal, *Islam without Europe: Traditions of reform in eighteenth-century Islamic thought* (2018), selections

→ Ali Yaycıoğlu, "Global transformations in the 'Muslim world': Connections, crises, and reforms," in *The History of Islam*, Salvatore, Tottoli, Rahimi, Attar, Patel, eds., (Wiley-Blackwell, 2018), 433-458.

Discussion What were some of the important global economic, political, and cultural trends in the 18th and 19th-century contexts which impacted the Ottoman world?